

A failure to learn from one fire after another

County falls short on policy and protocol fixes after Woolsey disaster, experts say.

By JENNY JARVIE

Agencies across Los Angeles County were “overwhelmed.”

The Emergency Operations Center was “largely ineffective” in maintaining situational awareness.

Some notification tools were not “used or used often enough” in the early hours of the fire and there was “no clear, single, comprehensive voice” on evacuations.

These were the troubling findings of a sweeping report that examined the performance of L.A. County fire, sheriff, and emergency management agencies in the wake of the 2018 Woolsey fire, which burned 1,100 structures across L.A. and killed three people.

To a remarkable degree, they foretold many of the failures that would beset L.A. County during the even more catastrophic January firestorms that destroyed 17,000 structures and killed 31 people.

The after-action report on the Palisades and Eaton fires, released last week, found staff lacked training and no clear chain of command. The county struggled to monitor rapidly unfolding events without streamlined coordination tools and operated with “unclear” and “outdated” policies and protocols when deciding when to send evacuation warnings and orders.

As The Times reported in January, officials took hours to issue evacuation orders to a large swath of west Altadena. When the order finally went out, homes in the area were already ablaze. All but one of the 19 deaths in the Eaton fire occurred in west Altadena.

The seeming lack of progress — particularly the in-

[See Fires, A7]



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A DEMONSTRATOR, top, holds up flowers in front of federal agents on Saturday in Portland, Ore. On the same day in Broadview, Ill., protesters link arms.

California consumers get sticker shock ordering imports online

Every year, Ventura County resident Carlos Soto buys a Liverpool Football Club jersey for his son to celebrate the start of the soccer season. This year it was delivered with an additional bill of \$107.

“The UPS guy said he couldn’t release it unless I paid more,” said Soto, who owns the Historia Bakery Cafe in Thousand Oaks. “Until this tariff thing started, I’ve never, ever had a bill on top of my purchase.”

Soto declined the payment and requested a refund for the jersey, which he bought from the team’s official website for around \$150.

Since President Trump reversed a decades-old tariff policy in August known as

Trump’s tariff policy changes mean some shoppers are being hit with surprise fees when items arrive

By Caroline Petrow-Cohen

de minimis, online shoppers like Soto are sometimes getting hit with high, unexpected extra charges.

De minimis used to allow goods valued at less than \$800 to enter the country duty-free. The tariff exception applied to more than 1.30 billion packages sent to the U.S. from overseas in 2024, according to U.S. Customs and Border Protection.

Social media is full of reports of individuals struggling with surprise bills for their deliveries. On Facebook and elsewhere, buyers are venting about hundreds of dollars due on mouse pads, makeup and bridesmaid dresses.

One person on Reddit faced a \$4,700 fee

[See Imports, A10]

Energy cuts harm GOP areas too

Trump’s cancellation of funding will hit clean hydrogen projects in California.

By HAYLEY SMITH

The Trump administration last week escalated its efforts against renewable energy when it announced the cancellation of \$7.56 billion in funding for projects in 16 states, including California.

The U.S. Department of Energy said the 223 canceled projects — all of which are in states that favored Kamala Harris in the 2024 presidential election — were terminated because they “did not adequately advance the nation’s energy needs, were not economically viable, and would not provide a positive return on investment of taxpayer dollars.”

But while the cuts took aim at blue states, they will affect Trump’s base as well: The terminated projects span districts represented by 108 Democratic members of Congress and 28 Republicans. In California, that includes large swaths of the Central Valley and Inland Empire, which largely leaned toward Trump in 2024.

Russell Vought, director of the White House’s Office of Management and Budget and a top Trump administration official, said in a post on X that the canceled projects were using “Green New Scam funding to fuel the Left’s climate agenda.”

The biggest cut was \$1.2 billion for California’s ambitious project to develop clean hydrogen known as the Alliance for Renewable Clean Hydrogen Energy Systems, or ARCHES. It was awarded by the Biden administration as part of a competitive nationwide effort to develop hydrogen projects. The idea is that the hydrogen, which burns at a very high temperature, will be able to replace planet-warming fossil fuels in some industry and transportation uses.

[See Energy, A6]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

CLEO SINNOTT, 3, left, and her sister Maja, 2, from Sydney, tour a flying taxi at the Grove last year.

Flying taxis could beat the Olympics to L.A.

Hunt is on for landing sites pending approval by the FAA, which could come next year.

By ROGER VINCENT

With electric air taxi services on the horizon, operators are already flying in to secure landing sites in Los Angeles.

Traffic-dodging aerial hops across big cities could happen as soon as next year, pending approval by the Federal Aviation Administration, and one of the country’s largest operators of airplane and helicopter landing sites is now on the hunt for L.A. locations that can handle the comings and goings of air taxis.

The vertiports, as they are called, might be built on open land next to an airport or university, or also on a parking garage or other building rooftop in downtown areas, said Kevin Cox, chief executive of VertiPorts by Atlantic.

The company wants to build the infrastructure needed to integrate air travel into congested urban centers as an alternative to stop-and-go car trips.

In its search for vertiports, the company is looking for busy surface routes “where it should take 30 minutes to get from point A to point B, but it takes an hour and a half,” Cox said.

“Southern California area has got a lot of challenges in terms of congestion on the roadway,” he said.

California has several

[See Flying taxis, A10]

Mogul’s son pitched elite car club; investor lawsuits followed

By JAMES QUEALLY

On paper, “The Bunker” was an ideal playground for Southern California’s ultrarich.

Described as “the ultimate man cave,” a \$14,500 monthly membership offered access to a fleet of high-end vehicles including Ferraris, Bugattis and Porsches, according to investor decks obtained by The Times.

Members were promised curated dining experiences, lavish private spaces, high-

end wines and cigars. Founding members purportedly included venture capitalist Mark Cuban, fashion designer and L.A. oil fortune scion August Getty, NBA champion Kristaps Porzingis and Oracle founder Larry Ellison, according to a lawsuit filed by two investors.

The Bunker’s fleet of supercars would call Beverly Hills home, as soon as its ownership group completed an approximately \$90-million takeover of Mr. C’s Beverly Hills Hotel, according to an executive summary of the

business reviewed by The Times.

From 2020 to 2022, the man behind the Bunker hooked investors on his hyper-ambitious project, meeting with business owners in ritzy parts of the West-side and hosting gatherings at Formula One events around the globe, according to a lawsuit and investors interviewed by The Times.

Some said they decided to buy in based on the last name of the Bunker’s chief executive, as it signaled a connection to the nation’s

[See Club, A14]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

DODGERS TRY TO DELIVER

Blake Snell and L.A. look to win Game 2 of their playoff series against Philadelphia. For coverage, visit our e-newspaper and latimes.com/sports.

Israel, Hamas hold peace talks

The meetings began just before the second anniversary of the attack that led to the war in Gaza. **WORLD, A3**

Early screening for dyslexia

California will start evaluating young children to identify reading difficulties. **LEARNING, A8**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 77/60. **B6**



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